US INFANTRY

When the United States entered World War I in April 1917 it was in the process of expanding its regular army to 140,000 men and creating a volunteer reserve of 400,000, incorporating the National Guard. These numbers were, however, wholly insufficient for the mass army needed for the European war. The government decided to create a new "national army" raised entirely by conscription. Despite traditional hostility to the draft, conscription went ahead smoothly, but it was a slow process assembling and transporting troops to Europe. The American Expeditionary Force numbered over 500,000 by June 1918, when it first entered combat on the Western Front. Nicknamed "doughboys", the conscripts impressed jaded Europeans as physically fit, mentally fresh young men, their optimism contrasting sharply with the cynicism of the war-weary British and French.

The US troops' inexperience, and that of their officers, cost them dearly in early engagements. Their supply system was often poorly organized and troops at times went hungry in their trenches. Apart from rifles, most of their fighting equipment had to be supplied by the British and French. But the doughboy proved his fighting worth, most notably in the St Mihiel offensive in September 1918.

US forces were totally racially segregated. Some 200,000 African-American conscripts were sent to Europe, but only a fifth of these were allowed to serve in a combat role, in separate all-black divisions. By the end of the war there were two million US troops in Europe. Around 50,000 US soldiers died in combat; a similar number were killed by influenza between 1918-19.

Americans on the Western Front
Men of the 23rd Infantry Regiment fire a 37-mm gun at a German position during the successful St Mihiel offensive of September 1918, the first major US operation of the war.

US equipment
The Americans added a few new touches to the weaponry of the war, such as shotguns used to clear enemy trenches.



CAMOUFLAGED HELMET



WIRE CUTTERS

COMBINED KNIFE AND KNUCKLE-DUSTER





PUMP-ACTION SHOTGUN

CANADIAN INFANTRY

Canada had only a few thousand men in its regular army when the war began. Unhesitating in its support for Britain, the dominion invited volunteers to create a Canadian Expeditionary Force. Some 600,000 Canadians enlisted, of whom 418,000 served overseas. Organizing an army almost from scratch was a formidable task, but a body of hastily trained Canadian civilians-in-uniform was ready to take its place in the front line at Ypres in April 1915 – just in time to face the first chlorine gas attacks on the Western Front. As Canadian numbers grew, so did their exposure to the worst the war could show. Canadians suffered heavy casualties at the Somme in summer 1916 and in the mud of Passchendaele the following year. Their exceptional fighting qualities were universally recognized. The Canadian capture of heavily defended Vimy Ridge on 9 April 1917, charging up a steep bare slope in sleet and snow, was one of the great feats of arms in the war. More than 56,000 Canadian soldiers died in combat.

> "...ITS ASSAULT ONLY FAILED ... BECAUSE DEAD MEN CAN ADVANCE NO FURTHER."
>
> **GEN. BEAUVOIR DE LYLE**
> ON THE NEWFOUNDLAND REGIMENT AT THE SOMME

Canadian weapons and kit
The Canadians' khaki uniform was based on the British one, but they produced their own rifle, the Ross, which had an unusual short, stubby bayonet.

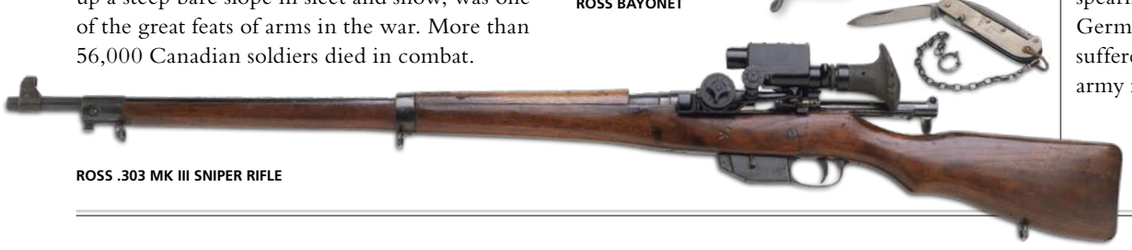


INFANTRY CAP



ROSS BAYONET

POCKET KNIFE



ROSS .303 MK III SNIPER RIFLE

THE ANZACS

On the outbreak of war, young men in Australia and New Zealand responded eagerly to their governments' call for volunteers to fight in support of Britain – about one in five male New Zealanders eventually joined up. Grouped together as ANZACs, Australian and New Zealand troops were initially stationed in Egypt for training. The Australians in particular soon gained a reputation as tough characters. Their indifference to military etiquette outraged British officers and their off-duty behaviour appalled the Egyptians. Once in battle, however, ANZAC troops proved the most fearsome and effective fighters on the Allied side in the war. Their baptism of fire in the notorious Gallipoli campaign would have demoralized a less resolute body of soldiers, but they went on to fight at the Somme and Passchendaele. By summer 1918 the Australians had their own corps, which spearheaded the offensives that rolled back the German Army. Proportionally, the Australians suffered the highest casualty rate of any national army in the war, with 60,000 killed and 220,000 wounded out of around 320,000 sent for overseas service. New Zealand suffered 58,000 casualties, including 17,000 dead.